

Syllabus

MAT 5173 — Algebra 1 Fall 2026 · UT San Antonio

Course Information

Catalog Entry

[MAT 5173 Algebra 1](#)

Groups, rings and fields, with emphasis on concrete number-theoretic and computational examples.

Prerequisites

Graduate standing, or consent of instructor.

Credit Hours

3

Course Modality

Traditional in-person

Class Meetings

Duration	Wed 19 Aug – Thu 3 Dec
Campus	Main Campus
Location	TBD
Time	Mon Wed TBD

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course you should be able to:

- State and use the definitions of group, subgroup, homomorphism, coset and quotient group, in each case on a concrete example built from modular arithmetic.
- Carry out and explain the Euclidean algorithm, the fundamental theorem of arithmetic, and modular exponentiation.
- Explain the RSA cryptosystem in terms of the group of units of $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$, and execute it on small parameters.
- State and use the definitions of ring, ideal, quotient ring, integral domain and field, on concrete examples.
- Explain unique factorization in the Gaussian integers and its consequence for representing primes as sums of two squares.
- Use a computer algebra system to explore an algebraic structure and interpret the output in writing.
- Explain one's own written mathematical work aloud, on demand, in response to questions.

About the Instructor

Eduardo Dueñez, Associate Professor of Mathematics.

Department	Mathematics
Office	FLN 4.01.11
Student hours	TBD
Email	eduardo.duenuez@utsa.edu

Email is the preferred method of communication.

Course Materials

Required

- Jürg Kramer and Anna-Maria von Pippich. *From Natural Numbers to Quaternions*. Springer, Springer Undergraduate Mathematics Series, 2017. ISBN 978-3-319-69427-6. Free to UTSA students through SpringerLink.

Additional reading

- Keith Conrad. *The Gaussian Integers*. Free handout; assigned reading for the final segment.

Assessment and Grading

Weight of course activities

Component	Weight	
Q&A sessions	40%	5 sessions, 8% each
Problem sets	15%	5 sets, 3% each
Midterm Exam 1	20%	Wed 30 Sep in class
Midterm Exam 2	25%	Wed 2 Dec in class

Q&A sessions

Five class meetings throughout the semester (roughly every other Wednesday except when adjacent to an exam) will be *Q&A sessions* in which each student will be asked to explain and defend their solution to a homework problem submitted as part of a written assignment. You will only be asked questions related to an assigned problem and about the solution you submitted.

Each Q&A session is scored 0–3:

- **3** Correct explanation to a correct solution, demonstrating full understanding of the concepts and all aspects of the solution submitted.
- **2** A completely correct solution submitted is explained to an incomplete degree; **Or:** an unfinished solution, with a thorough and articulate account of what you tried, explaining where and why you got stuck while demonstrating knowledge of the background and reading necessary to solve the problem.

- **1** Correct solution inadequately explained revealing little or no understanding; *or*: partial solution accompanied by an incomplete but partly correct oral explanation.
- **0** Nothing submitted; *or*: work submitted (even if fully correct) is backed by no cogent explanation nor knowledge of concepts involved.

A correct answer you cannot explain is worth less than an explainable honest failure.

Note: A Q&A average ≤ 1.0 automatically caps the course grade to the level of ‘D’ (at most).

Problem sets

Five sets, each with three or four theoretical problems plus one SageMath computer exploration. **Maximum three pages.** Do *not* submit code; include the relevant snippets and output as part of your written submission. (SageMath problems are also included in Q&A.)

Each item will be scored *only* based on the **degree of completion** (not on correctness): **2** for a nominally complete solution, **1** for a clearly partial one, **0** for nothing submitted or for obvious filler with no substance.

Note: Any submission containing non-human-readable content, stray characters, or artifacts revealing non-proofread AI output scores 0 for that item.

Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

AI assistance is allowed in preparing work for submission, as are any solution keys, collaboration, and internet sources. You are ultimately responsible for your submissions; any part of your work that has clearly not been proofread (e.g., includes non-human readable characters or LLM artifacts) automatically earns a zero grade. *Include one line noting what resources you used in your submission.*

This policy is by design, and it reflects how the course is graded: 85% of the grade comes from Q&A sessions and in-class exams where only what is truly understood and can be explained counts. Assignments submitted but not written/understood by you result in failing grades in Q&A sessions and exams. Use AI to learn faster —not to prepare and turn in papers you cannot defend, blocking you from passing exams as well.

Exams

Both exams are traditional in-class (written and closed book). Exams are based **primarily on the assigned problem sets** —expect some context and phrasing to differ from the homework, plus a minority of other unseen problems. Memorizing solutions will not result in good exam grades; preparing by understanding the assigned problems will make the exams straightforward and earn high Q&A grades as well.

Attendance and missed work

No extensions on problem sets. A *single* missed Q&A session in the semester may be made up during office hours within seven days (no documentation is required). *No Q&A scores are dropped.*

Final grade ranges

Grade	Range	Grade	Range
A	[90%, 100%]	A-	[85%, 90%)
B+	[80%, 85%)	B	[76%, 80%)
B-	[72%, 76%)	C+	[69%, 72%)
C	[65%, 69%)	C-	[60%, 65%)
D	[50%, 60%)	F	[0%, 50%)

Time Commitment Expectations

Expect an average of about **9 hours per week**, and no fewer than 7.

- Attend class meetings (**3 hours per week**)
- Reading the assigned textbook sections (**2–3 hours per week**)
- Problem sets and the Sage exploration (**2–3 hours per week**)
- Office hours and study group (**1 hours per week**)

Additional Course Information

Each student should be intimately familiar with the contents of any work submitted for grading. The instructor has the right to request adequate **verbal explanation** of methodology and content for any submitted work. Credit will not be awarded when such an explanation is requested but not satisfactorily provided.

Course Schedule

Date		Topic	Reading	Due
Wed 19 Aug		Course launch; the plane and its isometries	Rosebrock Ch. 1	
Mon 24 Aug		Reflections generate everything	Rosebrock Ch. 1	
Wed 26 Aug		From symmetry to the group axioms	Rosebrock Ch. 2	
Mon 31 Aug		Cyclic and dihedral groups	Rosebrock Ch. 2	Problem Set 1
Wed 2 Sep	Q&A	Q&A session 1		
Wed 9 Sep		Permutations and the sign homomorphism	Beardon Ch. 1	
Mon 14 Sep		Subgroups; Cayley graphs	Rosebrock Ch. 3	Problem Set 2
Wed 16 Sep	Q&A	Q&A session 2		

Date		Topic	Reading	Due
Mon 21 Sep		Cosets and Lagrange	Beardon §12.2–12.3	
Wed 23 Sep		Homomorphisms and quotient groups	Rosebrock Ch. 3 · Beardon §12.11–12.12	
Mon 28 Sep		Group actions: orbits and stabilizers	Rosebrock Ch. 4	
Wed 30 Sep	Exam	Midterm Exam 1 — Segment A		
Mon 5 Oct		Orbit–stabilizer and counting	Rosebrock Ch. 4	
Wed 7 Oct		Symmetries of the polyhedra; finite rotation groups in space	Beardon §14.2–14.3	
Wed 14 Oct		Finite groups; frieze patterns	Rosebrock Ch. 7	
Mon 19 Oct		Wallpaper groups	Beardon §14.4	Problem Set 3
Wed 21 Oct	Q&A	Q&A session 3		
Mon 26 Oct		Fields: $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$, and $\mathbb{F}_p$	Beardon §2.3–2.4	
Wed 28 Oct		Polynomials in one variable: division, gcd, roots	CLO §1.5	
Mon 2 Nov		Polynomials in several variables; affine space	CLO §1.1	Problem Set 4
Wed 4 Nov	Q&A	Q&A session 4		
Mon 9 Nov		Affine varieties — every graph is one	CLO §1.2 · Smith Ch. 1 handout	
Wed 11 Nov		Parametrization: lines, the circle, Pythagorean triples	CLO §1.3	
Mon 16 Nov		Ideals; $V(I)$, $I(V)$, and the coordinate ring $k[x,y]/I(V)$	CLO §1.4 + reading guide	Problem Set 5
Wed 18 Nov	Q&A	Q&A session 5		
Mon 23 Nov		Which curves are rational? Cusp, node, smooth cubic	Shafarevich §1.1 (Bix §1 optional)	

Date		Topic	Reading	Due
Mon 30 Nov	<i>Review</i>	Review — the exam pool		
Wed 2 Dec	Exam	Midterm Exam 2 — Segment B weighted		

Department and University Policies

Ombudsperson

The ombudsperson is an advocate who investigates complaints about a specific section or instructor and attempts to resolve them through mediation. Comments or complaints sent to this person will be brought to the attention of department leadership, who will follow up. If you have questions about the logistics of your class, please contact the instructor.

Contact Ilse Rosales Martinez at ilse.rosalesmartinez@utsa.edu.

Video and Audio Recording

As the instructor of this course, I may record meetings and lessons. You are expected to follow appropriate University policies and maintain the security of passwords used to access recorded lectures. Recordings may not be published, reproduced, or shared with those not in the class. If the instructor or a UTSA office plans any other uses for the recordings, consent of the students identifiable in the recordings is required before such use unless an exception is allowed by law.

Syllabus Changes

The syllabus is subject to change at the instructor's discretion. Any changes or corrections to the course materials, assignment dates, or other updates will be communicated to students ahead of time. You are responsible for checking Canvas for corrections or updates to the syllabus.

Essential Student Information

- **Important:** Bookmark and visit the [Common Syllabus Information webpage](#) for resources about counseling services, transitory/minor medical issues, supplemental instruction, tutoring services, academic success coaching, sexual harassment and sexual misconduct, campus safety and emergency preparedness, and the Roadrunner Creed.
- For technical requirements, support, and resources, visit [Academic Innovation's Student Technical Support page](#).
- UT San Antonio provides reasonable accommodations to students via [Student Disability Services](#), or call (210) 458-4157.
- Your well-being is important. Support, including [24/7 mental health services](#), can be accessed from the [Well-being at UT San Antonio](#) site.
- [Student Assistance Services](#) offers confidential support and personalized guidance.
- The [Roadrunner Pantry](#) provides free access to groceries, toiletries, and other essentials.
- Students are responsible for ensuring their work is consistent with UTSA's standards for academic integrity. Review [Section 203 of the Student Code of Conduct](#).

- Visit [UT San Antonio Libraries and Museums](#) for journals, research tutorials, and your department's librarian.